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AP

JUSTICE, AT LAST After years of outrage and relentless public pressure, in October 2006, the Delhi High Court overturned an acquittal and convicted Santosh Singh (above) for the 1996 rape and murder of law student Priyadarshini Mattoo. Two months later, it sentenced Manu Sharma (top) to life imprisonment for the 1999 killing of model Jessica Lall

THE JUSTICE VERMA COMMITTEE WAS CONSTITUTED, AND ITS RECOMMENDATIONS LED TO SWEEPING AMENDMENTS TO CRIMINAL LAW IN 2013

expanded, penalties enhanced, and new offences such as stalking and voyeurism introduced. The debate around juvenile culpability, sharpened by the role of a 17-year-old accused in the Nirbhaya case, eventually resulted in changes to the Juvenile Justice Act to allow harsher punishment for 16-18-year-olds in heinous crimes. On paper, the legal framework became significantly tougher.

The decade also witnessed important but fragile shifts in the understanding of sexual autonomy. In 2009, the Delhi High Court decriminalised consensual homosexual relations by reading down Section 377, marking a watershed moment for sexual rights. The Supreme Court's reversal of this judgment in 2013 exposed the limits of judicial progressiveness in the face of conservative social currents. That homosexuality was finally decriminalised again only in 2018 showed how uneven and contested this journey remained.

The years between 2005 and 2014 stand as a reminder that legal reform, while necessary, is not sufficient. Without sustained institutional reform and social change, outrage risks becoming cyclical, flaring after each atrocity and fading before justice is fully delivered. ■



RAVI S SAHANI

Not A Criminal
Dec. 30, 2013

"You may say you love each other, that you are happy with each other, that you give each other solace and courage and delight, but your love disgusts me. It runs counter to custom, it is an offence in law, it is against the order of nature, it brings dishonour to our family, it will dilute our blood, it will bring about kali-yuga, it will corrupt everyone around you, it is an abomination in the sight of the Lord. It must be forbidden."

